linking the site to the 11th century figure of Raja Bhoj, was however later dismissed as a 'misnomer' in the colonial gazetteer of 1908. Nonetheless, the Dhar state declared it a protected monument in 1909 and proscribed prayers in it. In 1934, the state placed a board outside it that mentioned Bhojshala. Namaaz was resumed in 1935 and the first Urs observed in 1944.

In 1952, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) took over the complex and reinstated the ban on prayers. In 1998, it gave Muslims permission to pray on Fridays and Hindus on Basant Panchami. A modified order of 2003 allowing Hindus to pray there every Tuesday was challenged in the Delhi High Court, but the petition was rejected.

The Hindu Front for Justice demands that only Hindus be allowed to pray inside the complex

The latest round of litigation began this year on May 2 with the Hindu Front for Justice filing a petition at the Indore High Court demanding that only Hindus be allowed to pray in the complex. The matter will be heard on June 27.

"The dewan of Dhar state allowed namaaz and *dua* for one day for the ruler's health in the late 1930s. Since then, the Muslim side has been present at the Bhojshala," claims Dipendra Sharma, secretary of the Bhoj Shodh Sansthaan. The Muslims, who have a family serving the dargah for close to 700 years, counter the claim. As per the ASI's arrangement, Hindus and Muslims pray inside the complex on the designated days. In 2016, the last time Basant Panchami was on a Friday, both sides offered prayers amid heavy police presence. ■

–Rahul Noronha



CHIKMAGALUR

BABA BUDANGIRI

HILLTOP BATTLE

Last December, a video clip of saffron-clad participants at the annual Datta Jayanti celebrations in Karnataka's Chikmagalur town circulated on social media, with prominent BJP leaders from the region averring that "Datta Peeta will come to the custody of Hindus" and that the shrine "is, was and will always be of Hindus". An hour's drive north of the town leads to a ridge atop which lies the Sri Guru Dattatreya Baba Budan Swamy Dargah, a cave shrine where both Hindus and Muslims come to worship. With the Vishwa Hindu Parishad, Bajrang Dal and the BJP organising rallies to the shrine through the 1990s and the early 2000s, it has been another Ayodhya in the making in the south.

The root of the dispute goes back to the 1960s when the Karnataka government transferred the property from its Muzrai department (which manages Hindu religious institutions) to the list of Wakfs. A lawsuit was filed before the district judge after the Wakf Board took over the shrine in 1975, and this court decreed in 1980 that it was not a Wakf property. Dismissing the Wakf Board's appeal, the Supreme Court in 1991 lauded both the hereditary